

Design Plan Checklist

Design isn't decoration. It's your booking engine, and there's no neutral design; it's either working for you or against you. Fill this in before you buy a single piece of furniture. Work the four sections in order: guest profile, function, durability, aesthetics. Before every purchase, ask one question: "Does this look good in a photo?" Design lives on the screen, not in the room.

Property: _____ Max sleepers: _____

1. Guest Profile

Your anchor already picked your guest. A national park pulls families and adventure seekers, a hospital or a base pulls work travelers, a scenic getaway town pulls couples. You don't have to appeal to everyone. You have to nail it for one.

☐ My anchor: _____ My guest avatar: _____

☐ Design list for that avatar checked:

- **Families:** queen bunks, trundle beds, toy baskets, board games, kid-friendly dishware, durable rugs, a table large enough for everyone at once
- **Couples:** romantic lighting, plush bedding, robes, a fire pit, cozy nooks built for two
- **Work travelers:** a desk nook with an ergonomic chair (or a standing desk), fast WiFi, lighting that doesn't ruin video calls
- **Adventure seekers:** gear hooks, boot trays, lockable storage, an outdoor shower, a welcome book that points them to the good stuff

☐ **Comp audit done before spending a dollar.** Top 3–5 comps: screenshot 10–15 photos each, read the reviews for what guests praise and complain about, check pricing and occupancy, and name the gap you'll fill.
Gap: _____

2. Function

You're not decorating a house. You're building a machine that sleeps people for money.

☐ **Capacity plan:** _____ sqft ÷ 100 = _____ target sleepers. Queen-over-queen bunks, trundles, and pull-out sofas close the gap (buy a good pull-out; a bad one generates bad reviews).

☐ **Seating and dining match the sleeper count.** [MAX GUESTS] dining chairs, [MAX GUESTS] place settings, [MAX GUESTS] mugs, and living-room seating where the whole group can land at once. You can't sleep twelve and seat four.

☐ **Amenities picked by the Candy Bar Method.** Validate every amenity with your market's data (Rabbu or similar) before you buy it. Roughly \$10K invested strategically in amenities has commonly generated \$1K–\$5K per month in additional revenue across our homes. The ranked list: hot tub (install \$3K–\$8K, commonly adds \$50–\$100 per night in my markets), fire pit (\$200 plus chairs), game room (\$2K–\$5K, has lifted occupancy 10–



20% in our leisure-market homes), quality linens and pillows (\$200–\$300 per bed, non-negotiable), outdoor shower (\$1K–\$3K in warm or adventure markets).

☐ Budget tier chosen:

TIER	COST	WHAT YOU GET
DIY	\$10–\$20 per square foot, plus your labor	Furnishings and décor only; you do everything
Design-only plan	\$3K–\$5K	A plan and a shopping list; no sourcing, no install, no staging
Hybrid	\$3K–\$5K plan + a VA for logistics	Most of the polish for a fraction of the fee
Full-service	\$8K+ in design fees; \$20K–\$40K+ all-in with sourcing, install, and labor	Market research, avatar work, trade discounts, install crews, a photo-ready home

☐ Design ROI run with your market's numbers, not the book's. Payback = Design Cost ÷ (New Revenue – Old Revenue). Reference math: \$30K of design lifting ADR \$220 to \$260 and occupancy 55% to 70% adds \$22,265 a year and pays back in about 16 months. If payback is under 18 months, spend the money.

3. Durability

Pretty design is useless if it falls apart after three groups of guests. The Hotel Standard Rule: if Hilton uses it, you should too.

- ☐ Sofas: performance fabric or leather. No light fabrics or delicate materials.
- ☐ Rugs: patterned, washable, or low-pile. They hide dirt and clean easily.
- ☐ Beds: solid wood frames or platform beds with center support. Cheap metal frames squeak and wobble.
- ☐ Tables: solid wood. Veneer chips fast.
- ☐ Hardware: matte black, bronze, or brushed nickel. Chrome shows every smudge.
- ☐ Linens: white towels and sheets only. Easy to bleach, consistent everywhere.

4. Aesthetics

Four decisions. Make them once, write them down, and every purchase afterward either fits the plan or goes back in the cart.

- ☐ 1. Style lane (pick one, never mix): ☐ Modern Cabin ☐ Coastal Chic ☐ Midcentury Modern ☐ Scandi Minimal ☐ Other: _____
- ☐ 2. Color palette, 3–4 tones max: _____
- ☐ 3. Repeated elements (same metals, woods, textures in every room): _____
- ☐ 4. One signature moment guests photograph and share (mural wall, statement headboard, neon sign): _____



Then plan the rooms:

- ☐ **Living:** sofa plus accent chairs (no two loveseats), rug large enough that all front furniture legs sit on it, styled coffee table, one or two oversized art pieces
- ☐ **Bedrooms:** real headboard, minimum 4 pillows per bed with a throw and blanket, matching nightstands and identical lamps, mirror or bench if space allows
- ☐ **Dining:** full-size table (extendable if possible), seating for max occupancy always, centerpiece, art or mirror to bounce light
- ☐ **Kitchen:** spotless counters with one or two styled touches (coffee station, plant, cookbook), essentials guest-ready
- ☐ **Bathrooms:** white towel sets, staged tray with soaps, spa touches (rolled towels, bath salts, candles)
- ☐ **Outdoors:** fire pit staged with at least 4 chairs, hot tub with jets on and cover visible, string lights at dusk
- ☐ **Lighting, three layers everywhere:** ambient, task, accent. Warm white (2700–3000K) in bedrooms and living areas, neutral white (3500K) in kitchens and baths, warm string lights and lanterns outside.
- ☐ **3–5 Instagram moments planned:** the welcome, the view or unique spot, the gathering spot, the bedroom escape, the detail
- ☐ **20% local flavor, 80% timeless design.** Local materials and one or two pieces from local makers, not bear wallpaper in every room.

Cross-check the Kitchen Items Checklist, Bathroom Items Checklist, and Photo Shot List in this pack, then move to the Design Plan Timeline.